

GCE Music

OCR Advanced Subsidiary GCE in Music H142

OCR Advanced GCE in Music H542

version 2 – February 2008

specification

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This booklet contains OCR's Advanced Subsidiary GCE and Advanced GCE specifications in Music for teaching from September 2008.

The OCR Advanced Subsidiary GCE and Advanced GCE specifications extend the GCSE skills of Performing, Composing and Appraising in ways that emphasise their interdependence. There are increased opportunities for the development of skills and understanding in performing and provision for their appraisal in *viva voce* discussion with the examiner. There are no limits on the instruments (or voices) and types of repertoire which may be presented in performance and the study of the widest possible range of music, including folk, popular and classical traditions of non-Western origin as well as those of jazz and Western classical and popular traditions, is encouraged.

Both specifications offer scope to develop creativity using music technology and in non-Western traditions, as well as more traditional tonal and non-tonal Western composing skills.

1.1 The Three-Unit AS

The Advanced Subsidiary GCE is both a 'stand-alone' qualification and also the first half of the corresponding Advanced GCE. The AS GCE is assessed at a standard appropriate for candidates who have completed the first year of study (both in terms of teaching time and content) of the corresponding two-year Advanced GCE course, i.e. between GCSE and Advanced GCE.

From September 2008, the AS GCE in Music is made up of **three** mandatory units, **two** of which are externally assessed (Performing Music 1 and Introduction to Historical Study in Music), and **one** that is internally assessed/externally moderated (Composing 1). Together they form 50% of the corresponding six-unit Advanced GCE.

The AS specification is suitable both for candidates who wish to proceed further in their study of music and for those whose interest is recreational.

1.2 The Six-Unit Advanced GCE

From September 2008, the Advanced GCE is made up of **three** mandatory units at AS and **three** further mandatory units at A2. **Two** A2 units are externally assessed (Performing Music 2 (Interpretation) and Historical and Analytical Studies in Music) and **one** is internally assessed/externally moderated (Composing 2).

The A2 units build directly upon the foundations laid in Performing, Composing and Listening in the AS specification. They develop candidates' skills to a level appropriate for entry to courses of study in music in higher education and provide access to a range of music-related employment, as well as offering an informed basis for a life-long appreciation and enjoyment of music. Their academic

rigour sets out approaches and lays down standards for critical judgement that may be transferred to candidates' learning in other subjects.

1.3 Qualification Titles and Levels

These qualifications are shown on a certificate as:

- OCR Advanced Subsidiary GCE in Music.
- OCR Advanced GCE in Music.

Both qualifications are Level 3 in the National Qualification Framework (NQF).

1.4 Aims

These AS and A Level specifications encourage students to:

- extend the skills, knowledge and understanding needed to communicate through music and to take part in making music;
- engage in, and extend their appreciation of, the diverse and dynamic heritage of music, promoting spiritual and cultural development;
- develop particular strengths and interests encouraging life-long learning and providing access to music-related and other careers; and
- recognise the interdependence of musical skills, knowledge and understanding and the links between the activities of performing/realising, composing and appraising.

They also encourage students to broaden experience, develop imagination, foster creativity and promote personal and social development.

The A Level specification also aims to:

- extend the skills, knowledge and understanding developed in the AS and provide a basis for further study.

1.5 Prior Learning/Attainment

The essential prerequisite knowledge, skills and understanding are those acquired through experience as a performer and an attentive listener. These should be at a level of attainment equivalent to that needed for successful completion of GCSE in Music but this qualification itself is not a prerequisite. An appropriate foundation may equally have been laid down within the context of the National Curriculum Stages 1 to 3, supplemented by extra-curricular participation in musical

activities or by following graded performance syllabuses offered by *conservatoire* examining boards, or it may have been acquired through wholly informal means, externally assessed or not.

2.1 Areas of Study

Two areas of study at each level provide an over-arching framework within which links between units may be developed. They each address important aspects of the study of music and are designed to offer candidates broad perspectives within which their skills and learning about details of specific repertoire, and their understanding of its cultural context, may be developed. The general principles learned can be applied to help candidates understand, and respond to, unfamiliar music.

At AS the areas of study are:

- **Tonality (The Language of Western Tonal Harmony)**
- **The Expressive Use of Instrumental Techniques**

At A2 the study of tonality is continued and an additional area of study is introduced:

- **Interpretation**

Tonality: at AS Level, candidates acquire a broad understanding of tonal principles within the language of Western tonal harmony and, at A2, they broaden this understanding by exploring more complex chords, tonal relationships and also non-tonal techniques of composing music.

The Expressive Use of Instrumental Techniques: instrumental writing skills and knowledge are developed to include idiomatic combinations of instruments and considerations of texture.

Interpretation: techniques and issues of interpretation are explored in all of the candidate's musical activities.

AS Areas of Study

Tonality (The Language of Western Tonal Harmony)

The dominance of tonal principles in the composition of Western classical music over three centuries, spanning roughly 1600 to 1900, makes this an essential body of prerequisite knowledge and understanding for any study of Western music. Its adoption by jazz in the 20th century adds further significance. Candidates are expected to know and be able to recognise the most common tonal language procedures in their performing and listening. This knowledge and understanding should then be applied in their own composition work.

They should learn to use and recognise aurally:

- primary and secondary triads, together with their inversions;
- seventh chords;
- rate of harmonic change;
- standard harmonic progressions within a clearly-defined tonal system;
- harmonic implication (for example, in a melody or a bass line);
- techniques of melodic repetition, variation and change within a defined harmonic pattern;
- modulation to closely-related tonal centres;
- tonal devices such as sequence and pedal.

The Expressive use of Instrumental Techniques

The starting-point for this area of study is candidates' own experience of performing. They are expected to:

- develop a fuller understanding of the nature and repertoire of their own instrument (including voice, which singers should understand in comparable terms);
- acquire knowledge about other instruments;
- develop their awareness of the sounds and performing techniques which characterise their own and other instruments, both as solo instruments and in combination with others; and
- develop an understanding of the principal contexts in which they are, or have been, used.

A2 Units

Each of the units at A2 builds directly on the equivalent unit studied at AS and each of the assessment objectives is again central to, though not confined to, a specific unit. The two areas of study again provide an over-arching framework within which more extensive connections may be made between the different activities of performing, composing and listening and between music and its context.

A2 Areas of Study

Tonality

The content is extended to include knowledge, recognition and understanding of more complex harmony and tonal processes as well as such approaches to harmonic organisation as pre-tonal, post-tonal and non-tonal techniques. A foundation for understanding how approaches to the handling of tonality have changed over time is laid down in Unit G356: *Historical and Analytical Studies in Music*.

Interpretation

The Performer as Interpreter: building on the appraisal skills applied both to their own performing and to differing realisations of Prescribed Orchestral Scores at AS Level, candidates demonstrate their interpretative understanding in a substantial recital and show, in a discussion with the examiner, how this has been informed by close critical listening to the interpretations of other performers.

The Composer as Interpreter: candidates choose an extra-musical stimulus (either text-based as a poem, narrative or storyboard, or one or more visual images) to interpret in a composition in their own choice of style and medium.

The Critical Listener: as well as a specific listening task designed to inform their performing, candidates extend their understanding of the composer as interpreter in Unit G356: *Historical and Analytical Studies in Music* through focussed listening, analysis and discussion of techniques used by composers, working at different times and in different cultural and musical contexts, to interpret extra-musical stimuli.

OCR-assessed Practical Examination (visiting examiner)

Section A Recital: solo (maximum 8 minutes)

60 marks

Section B *Viva voce*: discussion (approximately 5 minutes)

20 marks

Section C Extended Performing: **one** of

- performing on a second instrument (maximum 4 minutes)
- further performance on the recital instrument in an ensemble or duet or as an accompaniment (maximum 4 minutes)
- performing own composition (maximum 4 minutes)
- improvisation (maximum 2 minutes plus 10 minutes preparation time)

40 marks

Unit G352: Composing 1

90 marks